

Bipolar Disorder

Francisco Chen, Joy Li, Hannah Higgins, Harper Lau

Introduction

Bipolar Disorder is a mental health condition that causes effects on a person's mood, energy, behavior, and thought. There are two extreme ranges of mood changes in bipolar disorder, one is emotional highs called manic episodes, while milder forms are called hypomanic episodes. The other one is emotional lows called depressive episodes. These mood changes can make relationships, performance, and daily life significantly more difficult and cause disability. Although bipolar disorder is a lifelong condition and usually does not go away on its own, an improved quality of life can be managed successfully through proper treatment, support, and healthy lifestyle habits. It is important to learn about bipolar disorder because it helps to reduce barriers and prejudice, which encourages people to seek help when needed.

Symptoms

The symptoms of bipolar disorder often vary for each person, but most individuals with the disorder experience either manic episodes, depressive episodes, or "mixed" episodes—which are a combination of both manic and depressive symptoms. Manic episodes refer to periods when a person's mood or energy becomes much higher than normal. During a manic episode a person may feel overly excited, energetic, or irritable and may also sleep less and act on impulses rather than rational thinking. In some cases, the symptoms can be severe enough that a person may need hospital care.

Depressive episodes are characterized by symptoms such as anxiety, restlessness, and intense sadness. Mixed episodes involve a combination of both manic and depressive symptoms.

Episodes can last from a few days to several weeks, and symptoms may develop during late adolescence or early childhood, though they sometimes begin in childhood.

Additionally, people with Bipolar I disorder are usually characterized by manic episodes that last for a period of seven days, while people with Bipolar II disorder are defined by a pattern of both depressive and hypomanic episodes, which are less severe than typical full manic episodes.

Causes

Although the main cause of bipolar disorder is still being researched, scientists have found that genetics, brain structure, and environmental factors contribute to the disorder's development. Research shows that bipolar disorder tends to run in families, suggesting that people who inherit certain genes are more likely to develop bipolar disorder than others. However, the exact genes responsible are still unknown, as studies indicate multiple genes are involved in its development.

Furthermore, research has shown that brain structure and function of individuals with bipolar disorder may differ from those without the disorder. Studies suggest that bipolar disorder is often associated with differences in certain brain regions, such as the hippocampus and prefrontal cortex, as well as imbalances in brain chemicals. Lastly, although loosely established, there is some evidence that environmental factors can increase the likelihood of developing bipolar disorder. For example, infections during the fetal period and maternal smoking are two factors that may impair a child's neuropsychological health and increase the risk of psychiatric disorders. Seasonal changes have also been linked to bipolar disorder, with an increase in manic episodes during the spring and summer and an increase of depressive episodes during the fall and

winter. Additionally, a history of childhood trauma has shown a positive correlation with developing bipolar disorder.

Stages

Bipolar disorder is typically categorized into four stages based on severeness. In Stage 1, there are little to no symptoms present in the patient between mood swings, and the patient is able to complete daily tasks independently. During Stage 2, the patient experiences mild depression in between mania and depression. As the patient enters Stage 3, mood swings become more frequent and daily life activities are hard to be completed independently. In Stage 4, which is the most severe stage, the patient suffers a high frequency of mood change and they are not able to self-care.

Types of Bipolar Disorder

The first type is Bipolar I Disorder. This type is mainly defined by the presence of at least one manic episode. In Bipolar I, the manic episode is the key feature that separates it from other types of bipolar disorder. According to the National Institute of Mental Health, manic episodes in Bipolar I usually last at least seven days, or they may be severe enough to require hospital care. Depressive episodes may also occur, but they are not required for the diagnosis of Bipolar I Disorder.

The second type is Bipolar II Disorder. This type involves a pattern of depressive episodes and hypomanic episodes, but not full manic episodes. Hypomania is similar to mania, but it is usually less severe and does not cause the same level of impairment or hospitalization. Because hypomania can sometimes feel like increased productivity or confidence, Bipolar II may

be harder to recognize at first. However, the depressive episodes in Bipolar II can still be serious and long-lasting. The main difference is that Bipolar II includes hypomania instead of full mania.

The third type is Cyclothymic Disorder, also called cyclothymia. This type involves repeated shifts between hypomanic symptoms and depressive symptoms over a long period of time. However, these symptoms are not strong enough or do not last long enough to meet the full criteria for a hypomanic episode or a major depressive episode. In simple terms, cyclothymia is a more chronic pattern of mood changes, where the mood swings are noticeable but usually less extreme than Bipolar I or Bipolar II. Even though it may sound “milder,” it can still affect a person’s daily life, relationships, and stability.

Another category is Other Specified Bipolar and Related Disorder. This diagnosis is used when someone has clear bipolar-like symptoms, but their experiences do not fully match the criteria for Bipolar I, Bipolar II, or cyclothymic disorder. For example, a person may have hypomanic symptoms that are too short in duration, or mood episodes that do not fit neatly into the main categories. This category helps doctors recognize that the person is still experiencing meaningful mood instability, even if it does not follow the classic pattern exactly.

The final category is Unspecified Bipolar and Related Disorder. This is used when a person shows symptoms related to bipolar disorder, but there is not enough information to place them into a more specific type. For example, it may be used in situations where a clinician needs to describe bipolar-related symptoms but cannot yet determine the exact pattern. This category is less specific, but it still recognizes that the person’s symptoms belong somewhere within the bipolar-related spectrum.

Overall, the types of bipolar disorder are mainly separated by the severity and pattern of mood episodes. Bipolar I involves full manic episodes, Bipolar II involves hypomanic and

depressive episodes without full mania, and cyclothymic disorder involves long-term but less intense mood changes. The other specified and unspecified categories are used when symptoms do not fit perfectly into the main three types. These classifications help make bipolar disorder easier to understand and describe, especially because different people can experience it in very different ways.

Treatment

So far, the treatment of bipolar disorder is still focusing mostly on medications to help patients. The most studied treatment is antipsychotic, which is used to treat acute mania; Lithium on the other hand, is now the most effective treatment to prevent relapse (falling back to the original condition after a period of improvement). In cases when the patient shows resistance to drugs, electroconvulsive therapy is used. This therapy is a procedure that uses small currents to change some of the brain's chemistry in order to improve symptoms. Researchers are working on developing treatments for bipolar disorder that involve not only drugs, but also psychological and social support from healthcare providers.

Prevention

Bipolar Disorder cannot be prevented, but there are ways to reduce the frequency of severe episodes and improve mental health. Genetics can affect the possibility of someone getting bipolar disorder, people with a family history of bipolar disorder may have a higher risk of developing the condition. Early diagnosis and treatment are very important because they help manage symptoms before they become more serious. Maintaining healthy habits such as getting enough sleep, exercising regularly, a balanced diet, and managing stress can also help stabilize

mood changes. Avoiding drugs and alcohol is strongly recommended because these substances can trigger mood episodes. In addition, support and love from family, friends, counselors, and healthcare professionals can help people cope with challenges and maintain emotional balance.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Bipolar Disorder is a serious but manageable mental health condition that affects millions of people around the world. It causes extreme mood changes that can interfere with people's everyday life, but with proper treatment and support, many people are able to live healthy lives. The increasing awareness and knowledge of Bipolar Disorder can reduce misunderstandings and encourage compassion toward the people who got affected. By promoting mental health education and early prevention, society can help people with bipolar disorder receive the care and support they need.

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